

Which of the following scenarios best illustrates the psychoanalytic concept of regression?

- ☐ A. When a medical student receives a failing grade in his medical ethics class, he says that the instructor was "unprepared" and "incompetent." [2%]
- ✓ ☒ B. When a medical student is expelled, she spends her days watching cartoons and becomes attached to a childhood teddy bear. [92%]
- ☐ C. When a medical student finds out that he has failed his licensing exam, he becomes angry and throws his laptop on the ground. [2%]
- ☐ D. When a medical student struggles with a difficult rotation, she starts taking martial arts classes to channel her frustration. [2%]

Correct

92% answered correctly

Explanation:

Psychoanalytic theory: Major defense mechanisms (incomplete list)	
Projection	Attributing one's unacceptable thoughts/behaviors to someone or something else (eg, calling the sidewalk "stupid" after tripping)
Regression	Behaving as if much younger to avoid unacceptable thoughts/behaviors (eg, moving back in with parents to avoid adulthood stress)
Displacement	Taking out unacceptable thoughts/behaviors on a safe target (eg, punching a pillow when angry about being fired)
Sublimation	Transforming unacceptable thoughts/behaviors to acceptable thoughts/behaviors (eg, taking up boxing as a hobby to vent anger)

According to psychoanalytic theory, **defense mechanisms** are a largely **unconscious** means of **dealing** with **anxiety** or **stress**, often through **distorting** or **ignoring** aspects of **reality**.

Some defense mechanisms are more adaptive (eg, channeling unacceptable urges into a socially acceptable hobby) and provide an effective means of coping with stress, whereas others are less adaptive (eg, avoiding feelings through excessive alcohol consumption) and can result in additional problems (eg, unstable relationships).

Regression involves unconsciously acting much younger, often reverting to behaviors one hasn't engaged in for years (eg, thumb sucking) to avoid dealing with a stressor. An individual who experiences a distressing event (eg, expulsion from medical school) is exhibiting regression by spending her days watching cartoons and becoming attached to a childhood toy.

(Choice A) Projection involves attributing one's unacceptable thoughts and behaviors to another person or object. A medical student who fails a class reduces the anxiety he feels from thinking he is unprepared and incompetent by attributing those qualities to the instructor instead.

(Choice C) Displacement involves taking out one's unacceptable thoughts and urges on a safer object. A medical student who responds to news that he has failed his licensing exam by throwing his laptop on the ground is displacing his anger with himself onto his computer.

(Choice D) Sublimation involves turning unacceptable thoughts or behaviors into productive, acceptable ones. A medical student uses sublimation by taking her frustration out in an acceptable way through martial arts classes.

Educational objective:

In psychoanalytic theory, defense mechanisms are the largely unconscious means by which reality is altered (eg, distorted, ignored) to relieve anxiety or stress.

Time spent:0 sec
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System:
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